

17-inch LCD Monitors

OK, first a damper. Seventeen-inch LCD monitors are expensive—one panel costs as much as a fully-functional PC. However, prices here too have fallen, and the cheapest model this year is Rs 27,000—a drop of around 30 per cent from last year's Rs 38,000. But it is still an expensive proposition to buy one.

For our comparison, we tested 13 models from nine brands.

Features

The Samsung 173P offers the best contrast ratio and brightness of 700:1 and 270 cd/m² respectively, as per the specification sheet, making it the best choice for movie viewing and gameplay. The higher brightness means that that you can adjust the monitor to a higher brightness level when needed, while being able to reduce it when working with white backgrounds.

The brightness figure of 270cd/m² can light up the screen enough so you can view weapons placed on a corner table in a dimly lit room of an action adventure game. The contrast ratio of 700:1 can help adjust the monitor to get it to display any colour or shade; the slightest difference between shades become

VESA Wall Mount

Video Electronics Standards Association (VESA) is a non-profit organisation that sets standards for displays. These standards are adhered to by most display (CRT and LCD) manufacturers worldwide. VESA Wall Mount is the standard set by VESA, using which any brand of monitor can be mounted using any third party VESA-compliant wall mount fixture. Here we'll see how to fix an LCD with wall mount fixtures, and hang it on a wall.

1. First things first: check whether the LCD panel is wall-mountable. Look for four drilled holes at the back of the panel, at a distance of either 75 mm or 100 mm.

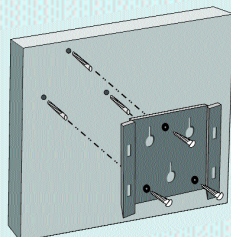
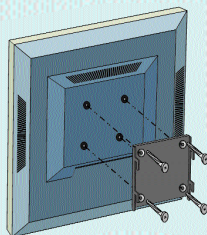
2. After this, remove the stand, or if the design allows, fold it. Now it's time to fix the sheet metal back plate—this comes bundled with some monitors, and can be bought from the manufacturers or third party vendors—which has four U-shaped pegs that fit into the grooves of the plate.

3. Now, the other plate that's provided must be fixed on the wall where the panel is to be mounted, with the help of bolts.

4. Match the four pegs of the back plate with the ones on the wall and hang the monitor.

5. Apply a little pressure on the panel to check whether the panel is securely fixed.

You can also opt for a mounting arm, which will offer you the flexibility of being able to move the LCD panel back, forward, up and down. This is more suitable for showroom owners and reservation counters.



Samsung SyncMaster 173P

This monitor is such a pleasure to look at, you'll watch it even when it's off. The panel has a round bottom with a silver lining, and a front panel just an inch in thickness. The panel can be height-adjusted, and can be both tilted and swivelled.

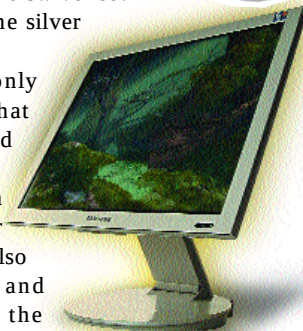
The front panel has just one silver button—the power button.

The 173P is also the only 17-inch LCD we tested that features the landscape and portrait modes. These features make the 173P a good display solution for professional use; it could also be used in showrooms and restaurants, gelling with the interiors.

And the performance is definitely something to write home about: the 173P returned the best results in the 64-intensities aspect of the primary colour test. The test screen was one of the more difficult ones to produce: there were 64 shades ranging from black to white, and this monitor reproduced them all brilliantly.

The only sore point about the 173P is the separate power adapter, which is bulky and hard to manage. At Rs 47,500, it's definitely on the higher side, but it's worth the money if you want the best.

- + Very good performance
- Bulky power adapter, expensive
- Price:** Rs 47,500



visible. This monitor also has highest video bandwidth—140MHz—of all the monitors in the comparison, allowing it to reproduce fine details at a higher resolution and refresh rate.

The pixel response time, which is the time each pixel takes to switch on or off, was the lowest in the Acer AL712 and the Umax V7, at 15ms. This means that the image quality on these panels should be the best, but low response time is not the sole criterion for performance; we didn't see either of these models top any of the performance tests.

Speakers are, more or less, considered a default accessory with LCD panels, and most of the panels we compared featured speakers, except for those from two vendors—Samsung and LG. If you want to wall-mount a panel, opt for the light Philips 170N. But a good set of speakers will set you back by another Rs 1,500 or so, eat up desk space, and increase wire clutter.

One good improvement in design we came across, compared to the LCDs of last year, was the drilled hole (see box 'VESA Wall mount'), provided with every monitor we tested. However, we